

society & the arts CYCLING

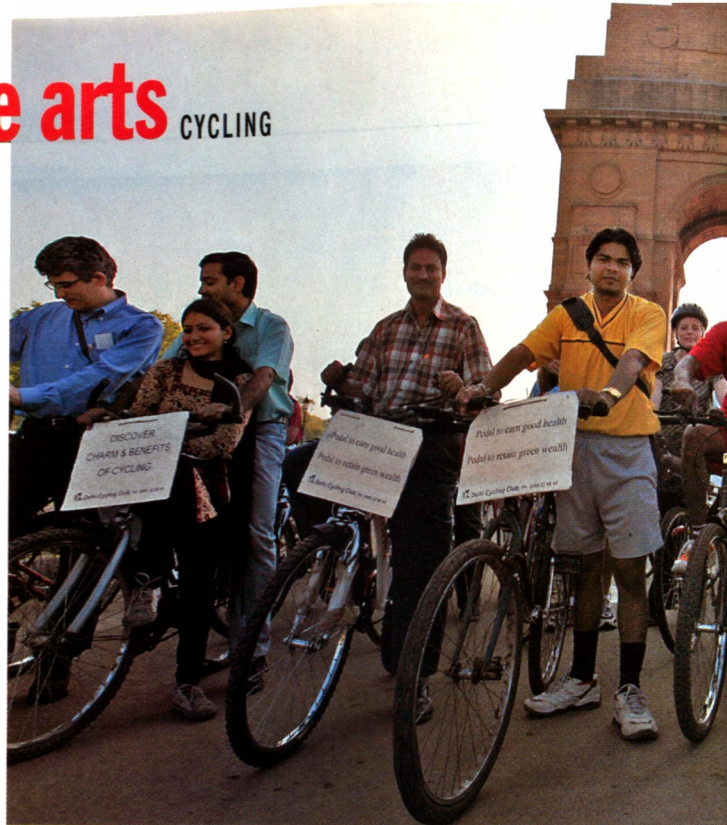
■ By Swagata Sen

It is a beautiful morning around India Gate. And Pradeep K. Aggarwal, 42, is basking in it as he travels on his bicycle beside the swooshing big cars. Looking on leisurely at the splendid structure that most hurried Delhiites don't give a second glance to, he ambles on with the wind blowing in his hair and a glow on his face that comes only with a deep sense of contentment.

Ask anyone who's ever pedalled a bicycle, and chances are that most people will associate the humble vehicle with some of their happiest memories—the first sense of achievement when the supporting wheels were removed and one perfected the art of balance in motion, or carrying one's childhood sweetheart on a date. The bicycle carries with it a host of memories. Aggarwal considers himself lucky as life still accords him the little pleasures. He has a car, but he cycles to his destination everyday, because he just loves to. In the Delhi Cycling Club, of which Aggarwal is a member, there are 300 people who think like him. All around the country, small groups of people have come together to bring back the bicycle as an alternative mode of transport. The Bangalore Bikers' Club, for example, has about 250 members, while their sister club in Mumbai, Mumbaibikers, saw thousands participate in a rally this year. Greentire, an organisation that is promoting cycling in Chandigarh, has successfully organised over 50 bicycle tours since 2000, along with hosting bicycle festivals and cycle games.

The unassuming vehicle is definitely making a comeback, this time as a lifestyle statement. As people are ready to spend, a number of advanced models have filled up the swanky showrooms in cities. While a basic bicycle ranges between Rs 2,500 and Rs 30,000, advanced models of brands like Firefox can cost a biker up to Rs 3 lakh. In fact, some of the world's biggest auto companies, like Harley-Davidson and Mercedes Benz, also manufacture bicycles that cost a king's fortune to buy and import.

The reasons for cycling are different for different people. It saves the earth,



RIDING ON A NEW

for one, as the bicycle is a zero-pollution vehicle. Which is why, Asish Gupta and his wife Priyanka, despite being time-crunched IT professionals, ride seven km to work from their home in Gurgaon. Even writer Sadia Dehlvi recently purchased a cycle rickshaw to make a statement against pollution. Actor Salman Khan, known widely as a fitness freak, often cycles to his shoots, while former police woman Kiran Bedi, who is a Delhi Cycling Club member, participates in cycling rallies with her daughter. It is no secret how much cycling can help in controlling blood pressure and obesity. In rush hour traffic, it often saves time. But mostly, it's an activity people love.

In a recent survey, 80 per cent students in Bangalore said they would love to cycle to school even if they had car drops. With three to five million vehicles clogging each city during rush hour traffic and an average of 1,000 vehicles being added to the roads



everyday, it is also a question of survival. Most cycling clubs in the country are finding more takers in the last couple of years. A Bangalore-based organisation called Bums on the Saddle, for instance, originally sold and facilitated test rides of mountain bikes, but two years ago decided to start the

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